Jie Song

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Education

University of California, Berkeley Expected May 2027
Ph.D. in Agricultural and Resource Economics

Georgetown University 2018
Master of Public Policy

The Chinese University of Hong Kong 2016
Bachelor of Social Science in Economics (Honors, First Class)

Research Fields

Economic Geography; Development Economics

References

Professor Thibault Fally
Agricultural & Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
fally@berkeley.edu

Professor Kirill Borusyak
Agricultural & Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
k.borusyak@berkeley.edu

Professor Marco Gonzalez-Navarro
Agricultural & Resource Economics
University of California, Berkeley
marcog@berkeley.edu

Job Market Paper

Breaking Away: The Endogenous Formation of Local Governments

Abstract: Why do communities form their own governments? A community that incorporates as a municipality chooses its own public services, property tax, and zoning, and it stops sharing its tax base with the rest of the unincorporated county. I separate these two motives using U.S. municipal incorporations from 1980 to 2020 and a model in which each jurisdiction chooses policies for its own residents. The gains come from retaining fiscal resources and from changing zoning policy, not from tailoring public services. Communities with a higher share of white residents and higher home values than their unincorporated county, as well as larger communities, are more likely to incorporate. Holding residents' location choices fixed, the average resident of an incorporating community gains 0.122% of income across 443 incorporators. Isolating the local tax base from the unincorporated county contributes 0.071%, the change in zoning policy a net 0.046%, and the service mix less than 0.001%. The average resident of the rest of the unincorporated county loses 0.011%. Within incorporated communities, college-educated residents gain on average and non-college residents lose. Because the gains are partly transfers, different approval rules for jurisdiction formation select different communities. Requiring a separate majority in the rest of the unincorporated county cuts expected incorporations by 50.7% and prevents mainly affluent communities; raising every state's entry barrier to at least the level estimated for California cuts them by 43.6% and falls more heavily on small communities.

Research in Progress

The Coordination Problem in Transportation Infrastructure Investment

Who Gains from Bringing Government Closer? Evidence from Ethiopia on the Gendered Effects of Decentralization

Other Publications

Biochar Supply-Chain and Challenges to Commercialization
With David Zilberman, David Laird, Coleman Rainey, and Gabriel Kahn.
GCB Bioenergy 15, no. 1 (2023): 7-23.

The Gendered Impacts of Income Fluctuations on Household Departure, Labor Supply, and Human Capital Decisions: Evidence from Kyrgyzstan
With Katrina Kosec, Hongdi Zhao, and Brian Holtemeyer.
Feminist Economics 29, no. 1 (2023): 205-235.

Aspirations and Women's Empowerment: Evidence from Kyrgyzstan
With Katrina Kosec, Kamiljon Akramov, and Bakhrom Mirkasimov.
Economics of Transition and Institutional Change 30, no. 1 (2022): 101-134.

Perceptions of Relative Deprivation and Women's Empowerment
With Katrina Kosec, Cecilia Hyunjung Mo, and Emily Schmidt.
World Development 138 (2021): 105218.

The Effects of Income Fluctuations on Undernutrition and Overnutrition Across the Lifecycle
With Katrina Kosec.
Health Economics 30, no. 10 (2021): 2487-2509.

Teaching Experience

University of California, Berkeley
Graduate Student Instructor (GSI); 2-3 discussion sections per week.

International Trade (Thibault Fally and Edwin Lai)	2023, 2025, 2026
Advanced International Trade (Kirill Borusyak)	2024
Environmental Economics (Steven Sexton and James Sallee)	2023, 2024
Development Economics (Marco Gonzalez-Navarro)	2022

Research Experience and Employment

University of California, Berkeley
Graduate Student Researcher for Andrés Rodríguez-Clare 2022
Graduate Student Researcher for David Zilberman 2021-2022

International Food Policy Research Institute 2018-2020
Research Analyst (supervisor: Katrina Kosec)

World Bank 2017
Research Intern, Procuring Infrastructure: Public-Private Partnerships

Georgetown University 2017
Research Assistant to Andrew Zeitlin and Jacobus Cilliers

Grants, Fellowships, and Awards

2025-2026	Giannini Foundation Mini-Grant ($35,000)
2024-2025	Giannini Foundation Mini-Grant ($25,000); Institute for Humane Studies Junior Fellowship ($6,000); UC Berkeley Outstanding Graduate Student Instructor Award
2023-2024	Fisher Center Research Grant ($15,000); Institute for Humane Studies Junior Fellowship ($6,000); Elinor Ostrom Fellowship ($3,500); ARE Summer Grant ($3,000); Institute for Humane Studies Grant ($1,500)
Earlier	McCourt School Tuition Scholarship ($20,000)

Presentations

2025-2026	UC Berkeley Trade Lunch; Development Workshop; ARE Department Seminar
2024-2025	UC Berkeley Development Workshop; Institute for Humane Studies Junior Fellowship Meetings
2023-2024	UC Berkeley Development Lunch; Development Workshop; Institute for Humane Studies Junior Fellowship Meetings
2022-2023	UC Berkeley Development Workshop
2019	Sustainability and Development Conference, Ann Arbor, MI (October) Annual Scientific Meeting, International Society of Political Psychology, Lisbon, Portugal (July)
2018	Student Conference, Association for Public Policy Analysis and Management, Washington, DC (April)

Professional Service

Refereeing: *World Development* (2); *Feminist Economics* (5)

Mentoring and tutoring 2024-2025
Mentor, Graduate Applications International Network (GAIN)
Tutor, Economists for Equity at Berkeley

Judge, Rausser College Honors Symposium 2023

Languages

English (proficient); Chinese (native)